

Disaster scams & false aid offers

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QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Pause before paying, sharing identification or following an urgent aid message. Verify the organisation using a contact you find independently, ask for written terms and avoid pressure to pay immediately. Keep emergency funds for verified essentials. A logo, uniform or forwarded link does not establish trust.

Do now.

- ☐ **Find an independent contact**
01 Use the organisation's known website or an existing trusted number rather than the contact in an unsolicited message. Confirm the specific programme or provider.
- ☐ **Protect personal information**
02 Share only what the verified process needs. Never give account passwords, one-time codes or a full identity document to an unverified caller.
- ☐ **Check payment demands**
03 Unexpected upfront fees, gift cards, cryptocurrency or pressure to pay immediately are warning signs. Ask for written terms and time to review.
- ☐ **Check repair offers**
04 Verify relevant credentials, references and a written scope before hiring. Do not let a door-to-door offer rush you into unsafe entry or a large advance payment.
- ☐ **Preserve evidence safely**
05 Keep receipts and message details without engaging further. Use verified consumer-protection or legal support when safe and available.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If reporting channels are unavailable, stop contact, protect remaining money and accounts, and retain the records for later. A promised refund is not a reason to make another payment.

Watch for.

An offer of transport or shelter may also carry exploitation risk. Do not surrender documents or separate from family because a stranger promises priority assistance.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group. Make decisions around the least mobile person, not the fastest; avoid splitting the family without a clear, safe way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: find an independent contact. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. An offer of transport or shelter may also carry exploitation risk. Do not surrender documents or separate from family because a stranger promises priority assistance.

Keep essentials within reach.

For disaster scams & false aid offers, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: If reporting channels are unavailable, stop contact, protect remaining money and accounts, and retain the records for later. A promised refund is not a reason to make another payment. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Warn trusted people privately about confirmed scams without circulating sensitive victim information. If payment or credentials were compromised, contact the relevant bank or provider through a known channel.

First decision: Find an independent contact

Use the organisation's known website or an existing trusted number rather than the contact in an unsolicited message. Confirm the specific programme or provider. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

If reporting channels are unavailable, stop contact, protect remaining money and accounts, and retain the records for later. A promised refund is not a reason to make another payment. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

An offer of transport or shelter may also carry exploitation risk. Do not surrender documents or separate from family because a stranger promises priority assistance. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Pause before paying, sharing identification or following an urgent aid message. Verify the organisation using a contact you find independently, ask for written terms and avoid pressure to pay immediately. Keep emergency funds for verified essentials. A logo, uniform or forwarded link does not establish trust. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For disaster scams & false aid offers, keep the specific hazard in view: An offer of transport or shelter may also carry exploitation risk. Do not surrender documents or separate from family because a stranger promises priority assistance.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Preserve evidence safely. Keep receipts and message details without engaging further. Use verified consumer-protection or legal support when safe and available. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

FTC · Recovering from a weather emergency

<https://consumer.ftc.gov/features/dealing-weather-emergencies>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/disaster-scams/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.